Improving Presentation Skills

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Objectives

Students will learn

- to prepare and organize a successful oral presentation in English.
- to avoid most common presentation mistakes.
- To use signposting language
- to control and enhance their body language.

Outline

- Preparation and Organization
- Most Common Presentation Mistakes
- Signposting Language
- Visuals
- Body Language
- Conclusion

Introduction

Secret to Presentation Success:

Research	
Choice of Words	13%
Tone of Voice	17%
Body Language	70%
Total	100%

Preparation and Organization

1. Essential preparation and planning Checklist

Questions to ask Yourself	Your ideas
1. What is the aim?	
2. What is my title?	
3. Who am I speaking to?	
4. What are the main points I want to make?	
5. What do I want the audience to do after listening to my presentation?	

Preparation and Organization

2. Structure of an oral presentation

❖**The beginning or the introduction**

- The beginning of a presentation is the most important part.
- It is when you establish a rapport with the audience and when you have its attention.
- The way you begin determines how your audience will respond throughout your presentation.
- Your introduction should consist of three parts; the grabber, the thesis, and the overview.

Preparation and Organization

- **THE GRABBER** consists of your introductory remarks, which set the tone for what is to follow. One purpose of the grabber is to gain audience attention and create positive expectations about the presentation. A second objective is to establish rapport with the audience and assist in overcoming barriers between the speaker and the audience. A third objective is to wake up the sleepy members of your audience, especially if your presentation is scheduled right after lunch!

Preparation and Organization

- **THE THESIS** is a statement of purpose for the presentation. This is where you present your position to the audience. You explain how the audience will benefit from the information, thereby providing the audience with a reason to listen.
- **THE OVERVIEW** indicates the main points which you will discuss in developing your thesis.The purpose is to show the audience what to expect so they can prepare to listen. This is especially important for global learners in the audience, who need to have a clear idea of the big picture before listening to the step-by-step details.

Preparation and Organization

- **Body**

The body is the core of the presentation, where you develop the thesis. This is where most of the information will be covered. The number of main points should be limited depending on the length of the presentation. Offering people too much information only makes them tune out. Provide sufficient information to support your thesis without repeating yourself or going into too much detail.

Preparation and Organization

❖ Conclusion

- **THE REVIEW** reinforces and summarizes the message. This is the part of the presentation when you can choose what was most important and what you would like audience members to remember. Choose three main concepts, ideas, or principles at the most.
- **THE CALL TO ACTION** is the impetus to use the information presented. This is where you tell the listeners what you would like them to do after attending your presentation.

Preparation and Organization

- **THE CONCLUDING GRABBER** signals the end of the presentation. The purpose is to create a memorable impression before your audience disperses. This short message may be what attendees describe or report to others on their cellphones as soon as they have finished attending your presentation. It's your last chance to leave a powerful impression.

Most Common Presentation Mistakes

- Lack of Preparation
- Poor Use of Visuals
- Inappropriate Humor
- Inappropriate Dress
- Not Knowing the Audience
- Non-Functioning Equipment
- Starting or Ending a Presentation Late
- Using a Monotone Voice
- Too Much Material in Too Short a Time
- Not Clarifying the Topic

Signposting Language

You need to guide the listener by using expressions to tell him/her where you are going (signposting language). That is to say, first announce what you are going to say (give an example, reformulate etc.) and then say what you want to say. This is very like verbal punctuation. Indicate when you have finished one point and then go on to the next one. It is redundant in text but very useful in oral presentations.

Signposting Language

- Listing information

-Lists are often necessary. Vary your language whenever possible and avoid reading directly.

Examples:

- ✓ There are three things we have to consider: one, two, and three.
- ✓ Now let us look at the first aspect which is…
- ✓ First of all,…
- ✓ In the first place…

Signposting Language

- Linking ideas, sections/making transitions

-Indicate the end of one section and the beginning of the next.

Examples:

- ✓ That's all I would like to say about… (subject of part A) and now let us turn to ….
- ✓ Now that we've seen… let us turn to…

Signposting Language

- Outlining options

-If there are alternative ways of looking at a topic or proposal, outline them to show you are familiar with the different ways of dealing with a situation.

Examples:

- ✓ There seem to be two possible ways of dealing with this…
- ✓ We've looked at this from the point of view of ……. but what about if we were to…
- ✓ A number of options present themselves at this point….

Signposting Language

❖ To give an example

- Now let's take an example.
- An example of this can be found…
- To illustrate this…
- Let's see this through an example.
- For example,
- For instance,

Signposting Language

- To rephrase

- Let me rephrase that,
- In other words
- Another way of saying the same
- thing is
- That is to say

Signposting Language

- To summarize

- To summarize
- To sum up,
- Let me summarize by saying
- So that concludes my overview
- In conclusion
- Briefly said
- In short,
- What I've tried to show in this part…
- To recap what we've seen so far…

Signposting Language

- To emphasize
  - What is very significant is…
  - What is important to remember…
  - I'd like to emphasize the fact that…
  - I'd like to stress the importance of…
  - to highlight…
  - What we need to focus on…

Signposting Language

- To refer to what you have said previously
  - As I have already said earlier…
  - As we saw in part one…
  - To repeat what I've said already…
- To refer to what you will say:
  - We will see this a little later on.
  - This will be the subject of part 3.
  - We will go into more detail on that later.
  - For now, suffice to say…

Signposting Language

❖ To refer to what an expert says:

- I quote the words of …
- In the words of…
- According to…
- Here I'd like to quote…
- As Mr. X says in his book…
- There is a famous quotation that goes…

Signposting Language

- To refer to common knowledge
  - As you all may well know…
  - It is generally accepted that…
  - As you are probably aware (of)…

Visuals

- What are visuals?
  - graphs
  - charts
  - maps
  - photos
  - drawings
  - images
  - models
  - video/film
  - objects

Visuals

- What media are used?
- transparencies/slides
- Power Point slides
- video projection/projector
- handouts

Visuals

- What should you put on a visual?

- key words
- technical words
- lists
- examples
- diagrams
- charts

Visuals

❖ Vocabulary of graphs/chart

- line graph (algorithmic, linear curve, line)
- bar chart
- flip chart
- diagram
- pie chart (segment, slice of the pie)
- flow chart
- organization chart

Visuals

❖ Why use visuals?

- to focus the audience's attention
- to illustrate points easier to understand in visual form but difficult in a verbal form (e.g. statistics)
- to reinforce ideas
- to change focus from aural/oral to visual
- to involve and motivate the audience
- to involve all the senses
- to serve as logical proof
- to help the speaker

Visuals

❖ **How many visuals?**

- One every two minutes is sufficient. To show too many slides is worse than none at all.

❖ **General and miscellaneous tips**

- Have the slides ready and in order.
- Check to see if the OHP is plugged in, in working order and in focus.
- Test the visual to see if people at the back of the room can see it.
- Stand to the side of the screen and face the audience.
- Use a pointer or a pen to draw attention to a specific point.

Visuals

- Visuals should be adjusted to the audience.
- Visuals should supplement the spoken message.
- Large enough for everyone to see.
- Don't display too much information, too many colors or typefaces.
- Does the layout work?
- Are there any spelling mistakes or grammatical errors? Remember they are going to be in plain view all the time of your visual.

Body Language

- The golden rule is "Be natural and relax!"

❖ What is body language?

- Eye contact, facial expressions, posture, movements, gestures.

❖Why is it useful?

- It is a natural part of communication:
- to clarify meaning; it is very visual
- to vent nervousness
- to maintain interest
- to emphasize and regulate

Body Language

- Positive body language

- eye contact to keep audiences' attention (Asian audience might feel aggressed.)
- facial expressions should be natural and friendly. Don't forget to smile.
- posture – stand straight but relaxed (do not slouch or lean)
- movement - to indicate a change of focus, keep the audience's attention (move forward to emphasize, move to one side to indicate a transition)
- gesture (up and down head motion or other movements to indicate importance, pen or pointer to indicate a part, a place (on a transparency)).

Body Language

- Negative body language

- loss of eye contact: looking at notes, looking at screen, at the board, at the floor
- don't stare, or look blankly into people's eyes
- swaying back and forth like a pendulum
- back turned to the audience
- nervous ticks
- hands in pockets

Body Language

❖ Voice

- The voice, or more precisely the qualities of the voice, should be used to its/their fullest.
- Qualities include loudness, speed (fast or slow), variety, pitch (high or low), silent moments or pauses.

❑ The voice is important:

- to indicate importance, meaning
- to create atmosphere and to avoid sounding monotonous and putting the audience to sleep!

Body Language

❖ Voice

- Paying attention to the factors below will improve the tone and quality of your voice.

- Speak Up
- Breathe Normally
- Use Good Diction
- Speak With Variety & Enthusiasm
- Emphasize Appropriately
- Sound Calm & Friendly
- Don't Rush
- Straightforward Language

Conclusion

Presentation skills can be learned and improved. You just need the will and practice to become a memorable and impressive speaker and presenter.

References

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